Lea’s case: Five transfers or two?

Bottom line. Two $500 transfers had lower estimated historical costs on 50 of 57 paired service records. Lea can use that pattern to decide which schedule to price first. The current quotes and her family’s timing needs should determine the actual schedule.

1. The person and the decision

Lea is a fictional hospital employee in Los Angeles who wants to send $1,000 in savings principal to family in the Philippines over the next five months. She is deciding whether to send $200 five times or $500 twice. Her family can wait for the larger installments, and Lea can set aside enough for either schedule. She wants to avoid repeated charges while getting the money there before her family needs it.

2. Their real situation and alternatives

Lea can ask her family when the funds need to arrive and which deposit or pickup options they can use. She can then request both amounts from the same provider using the same funding and delivery methods. The CFPB explains that prepayment disclosures show the exchange rate, fees and taxes, and expected amount received. It also notes that recipient-bank charges or foreign taxes can reduce what arrives. [1]

The World Bank’s public Remittance Prices Worldwide site offers a historical benchmark at both $200 and $500. Its methodology explains that prices are snapshots and that costs include the exchange-rate margin as well as the transfer fee. RemitRight LA makes the selected corridor and quarter easy to inspect. A provider’s current quote is the better source for pricing a transfer Lea is ready to make. [2]

Sources

[1] Consumer Financial Protection Bureau. Send money abroad with more confidence.

[2] World Bank, Remittance Prices Worldwide. Methodology.

3. The app in use

Open RemitRight LA. Select Philippines, 2025 Q3 and Cost & disclosure. Run Update analysis at USD 200, then change only the transfer amount to USD 500 and run Update analysis again.

Figure 1. Saved analysis confirms the route, quarter and $500 basket.

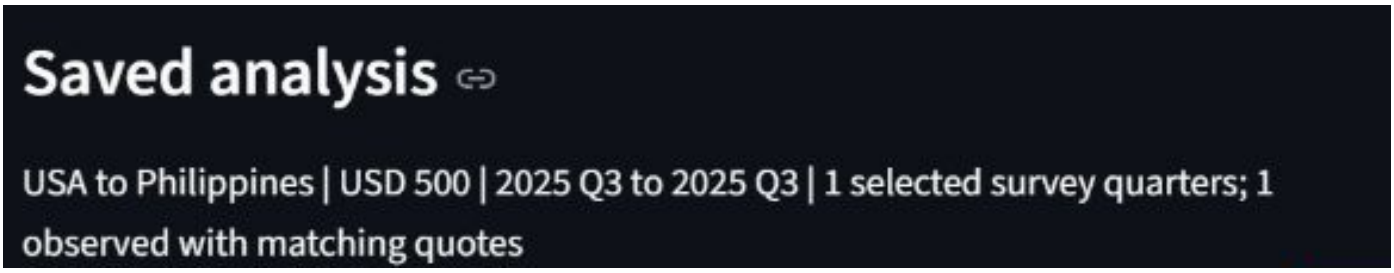


Figure 2. $200 basket: 3.960% median across 58 eligible quotes.

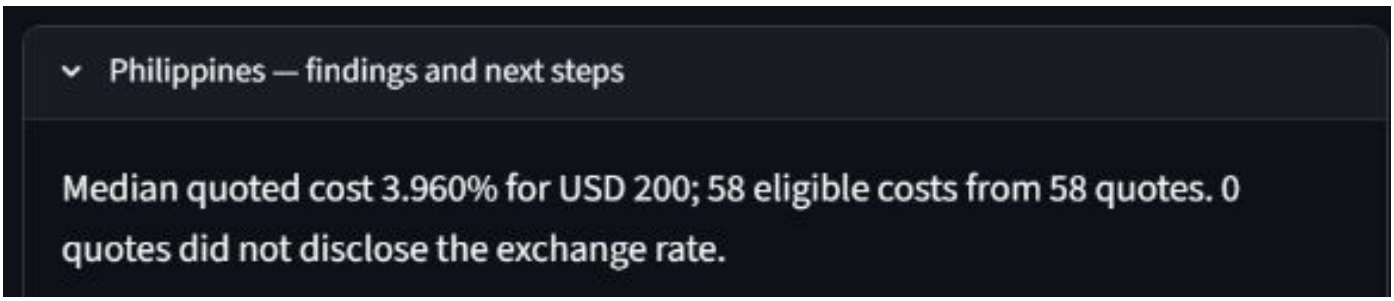
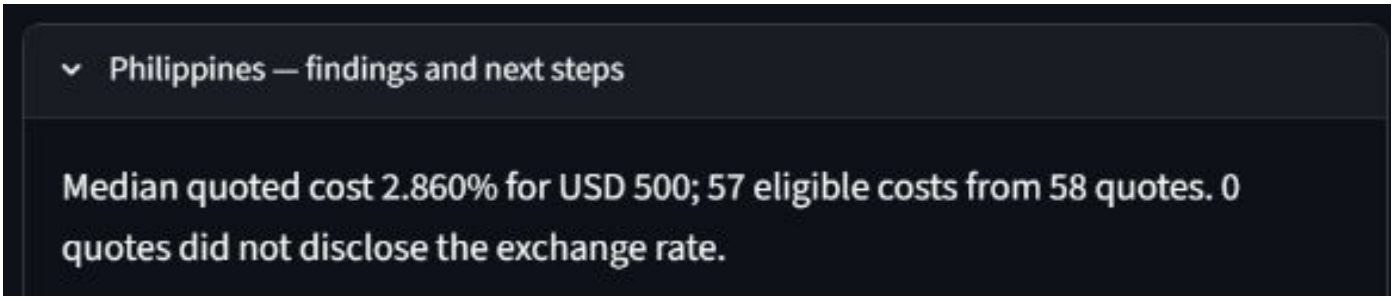


Figure 3. $500 basket: 2.860% median across 57 eligible quotes.



The two runs each found 58 historical service records. Both reported zero quotes flagged for exchange-rate nondisclosure. The $500 cost median uses one fewer record. Screenshots are cropped from the live app to show the saved settings and the cost findings.

4. Reading the result for their decision

Does the number fit? The app shows the median quoted cost rate for a single transfer. Lea cares about the dollar cost of a schedule. Multiplying the displayed rates by $1,000 gives historical benchmarks of $39.60 and $28.60. The $11.00 gap compares two medians with different eligible sets. It does not measure what Lea would save on the same service.

Who is in the rows? The project's cleaned RPW file has 58 U.S.-to-Philippines service records from August 2025. Each row describes a sampled service and its quote terms, without weighting by customer use. One Ria cash-funded agent/cash-pickup record has a $200 cost (5.49%) and a blank $500 cost. That row cannot support a paired comparison. Actual transfers and services outside the sample are outside the comparison.

Paired check. In `rpw_usa_clean.csv.gz`, filter destination PHL and period 2025_3Q. On each row with both `cc1_total_cost_pct` and `cc2_total_cost_pct`, calculate five times the $200 quote's dollar cost minus twice the $500 quote's dollar cost. Equivalently, subtract the two percentage values and multiply by 10. Of 57 pairs, 50 favored two transfers, 6 tied, and 1 favored five. The median paired difference was $13.10 in favor of two.

What could Lea misread? Treating the pooled medians as a same-service comparison is a *same mix* problem (11.5, kind 7). For one Western Union online credit-card quote to a bank account, the rates were 3.46% and 5.36%. Under the same historical-price assumption, two transfers cost $19.00 more on that service. A schedule that looks cheaper in the pooled view can cost more for a specific option.

What else matters? Repeating a historical quote assumes its terms hold across installments. Future rates, fees and delivery times can change. Lea also has to confirm when her family needs the money, how they can receive it and whether recipient-side charges apply. [1, 2]

5. The verdict: break

The app is useful for seeing how often a larger transfer was cheaper in the historical sample. For choosing a schedule, Lea is better off comparing current quotes for both amounts on services her family can use. The app's corridor median cannot establish her savings or the pesos her family will receive.

Change request for RemitRight LA. Add an optional paired-basket view within a corridor and quarter. Use only records with eligible costs at both amounts. Show the paired and excluded counts, the two implied costs per $1,000, and the distribution of paired differences. Label the results as historical and explain the constant-price assumption. Keep the existing corridor view available for outreach and trend users.